Poem for Jen

By Big Poppa E (Eirik Ott)

INTRODUCTION

The loss of a loved one is life's most stressful event and can cause a major emotional crisis. After the death of someone you love, you experience bereavement, which literally means "to be deprived by death." Often, death is a subject that is avoided, ignored or denied. At first it may seem helpful to separate yourself from the pain, but you cannot avoid grieving forever. Someday those feelings will need to be resolved or they may cause physical or emotional illness. Eirik Ott approached the one year anniversary of Jen O'Hare's death trying desperately to cope with her death. In an attempt to resolve his pain, he wrote and now performs nationwide this Poem for Jen by Big Poppa E. aka Eirik Ott.

There's a hole in my heart
in the shape of her smile
that will never be filled
I will never forget
the last sentence
of the article in the newspaper
the next day:

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"The terrible crash pancaked the tiny Honda Civic."
It rattled our minds
as we ran our fingers
across the gouges
in the pavement,
our eyes squinting
through a thousand glaring pinpricks
from windshield fragments,
searching
for lucky pennies
scattered
(hundreds of them)
from her broken penny jar.

"The terrible crash pancaked the tiny Honda Civic."
That sentence robbed us of closure.
We weren't allowed to marvel
at the mortician's handiwork
(she looks like she's asleep).
We couldn't cup
her lifeless hand —

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powdered
and colored
with an artist's touch —
and confirm
that it was true
that it actually really
had happened.
No, the terrible crash pancaked the tiny Honda Civic,
and they wouldn't even run photos because it's a family
newspaper and you can't run photos like that in a family
newspaper.
We had to just agree
nod our heads in unison
and agree that she was gone
and would never be back
this precious flower
plucked in mid-blossom.
And we held each other
and remembered her
as we had last seen her
pink and alive and smiling

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that big thumbs up smile
And we were warmed by the knowledge
that if anyone could've changed the world
she could've.
She would've
had she only been given the chance.
But now...
We'll always feel like she's out there somewhere
always at the corner of our eyes
in the summer sea of spaghetti straps and backpacks
tan lines and smiles
she'll be there at the corner of our eyes
and we'll catch our breath
turn and see nothing.
I think about that last sentence every time I drive, it
echoes in my brain as I near the spot on the four-lane
highway where she crossed the median and died.
I picture the time of day: around 11 a.m.
The sun was out. The sky was blue. There was no rain.
She was driving alone. She was probably smoking.
She was listening to James Taylor's Greatest Hits;

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we know this because the tow crew
pried that CD from what was left of her stereo.
And I grip my wheel white-knuckled
as I near the spot.
And I can't help counting down
the time she had left.
(and she didn't even know it was coming.)
It was a bright sunny day and she was singing...
"I've seen fire and I've seen rain" 20 seconds
"I've seen sunny days that I thought would have no end"
10 seconds
"I've seen lonely times when I could not find a friend" 5
seconds
"But I always thought I'd see you baby one more time
again..."

And JUST LIKE THAT we are past it and the scars in
the pavement are left behind.
And JUST LIKE THAT we are past it and the white
cross we left in the grass on the embankment is left
behind.

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And JUST LIKE THAT we are past it and the lucky
pennies and the photos and the little good luck tokens
and the letters and the constellations of shattered
windshield are left behind.
just like that *she*
was left behind.
The headline should not have read
"Chico State Student Killed in Car Crash."
No, the headline should've shouted in capitol letters
across the front page:

JENNIFER LYNN O'HARE KICKED SO MUCH ASS!

She was a poetess, a priestess, a goddess, a feminist, a
fighter, a lover, a laugher, a teller of truths, a spinner
of midnight balcony tales
shrouded in Heinekin and Camels...
(she could break down Brian Johnson's male chauvinist
arguments with the precision of a surgeon, hurling words
like "patriarchal" and "misogyny" and "hegemony" in a
rapid fire distillation of everything she had learned in

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Women's Studies classes, we almost felt sorry for Brian
as she leaned towards him on the edge of her stool
pointing with the glowing cherry of a lit cigarette...)
She was a God-awful drummer but a very enthusiastic
drummer, a deep and passionate kisser, a liver of life, a
lover of all things, not the best of students but the best
of teachers, a mentor, a sister, a daughter, a confidant,
a friend.
These words should have been displayed on the pages
of every newspaper in the world.
But they weren't.
Most people in this world probably didn't even realize
their loss.
And I feel sorriest of all for those people -- you --
those of you who never had the chance to meet her.
She was *that* cool.
The last sentence
in this poem
is how I will remember
Jennifer Lynn O'Hare:

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This world is a better place

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Big Poppa E. (Eirik Ott)
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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier

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